

COMPLETE CHESS LEARNING LIBRARY

Defense, Prophylaxis, and Counterplay

Find resources, reduce danger, prevent breaks, and stay active

COURSE BOOK

20 focused chapters - model positions - decision rules - retrieval practice

Designed to change what you notice, calculate, remember, and do at the board.

How to Use This Course

ONE CHAPTER, FOUR PASSES

1. Read the position without moving pieces. 2. State your plan and the opponent's counterplay. 3. Study the decision rules. 4. Close the book and reconstruct the position from memory.

RETRIEVAL SCHEDULE

Review the chapter the next day, one week later, and after a game that reaches a similar structure. Retrieval is more valuable than rereading.

BOARD ROUTINE

Opponent's threat - forcing moves - loose pieces - worst piece - central break - best reply - choose and stop.

The course book explains each model position. The separate workbook forces recall, prediction, and self-scoring. Use the book first, then attempt the matching workbook page without looking back.

Engine evaluations are intentionally not the lesson. The aim is to store human decision rules that remain useful when the exact move order changes.

Course Map

MODULE	CHAPTERS
DEFENSE, PROPHYLAXIS, AND COUNTERPLAY	20

01. What Did The Last Move Change?



DEFENSE, PROPHYLAXIS, AND COUNTERPLAY

READ THE POSITION

Study the square a piece left as carefully as the square it reached.

PRIMARY PLAN

LANDING: Inspect new attacks and blocks.; ABSENCE: Inspect the vacated square and lines.; PROTECTION: Notice defenders that disappeared.; INTENT: Name the likely next idea.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'They only developed' with 'Ask what became unguarded.'; Replace 'My plan still works' with 'Recheck the position after every move.'; Replace 'The threat is obvious' with 'Look for the quiet purpose too.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bc4 Bc5 4. d3 Nf6 5. O-O O-O 6. c3 d6 7. Re1

MEMORY RULE

Read the change first; make your plan second.

01. Decision Framework

What Did The Last Move Change?

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	RESET: Forget your previous plan briefly.; LANDING: Scan attacks from the new square.; VACATED: Trace opened files and diagonals.; DEFENDERS: Recount critical protection.; RESPOND: Choose a move for the new position.
PIECE JOB	ARRIVAL: What does the moved piece attack from its new square?; DEPARTURE: What line or square did it stop protecting?; PURPOSE: What future idea became easier for the opponent?
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	BOTH ENDS: Every move changes two squares.; LINES: Vacated squares often reveal tactics.; DEFENDERS: Protection can vanish silently.; INTENT: Predict the next move, not only this one.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

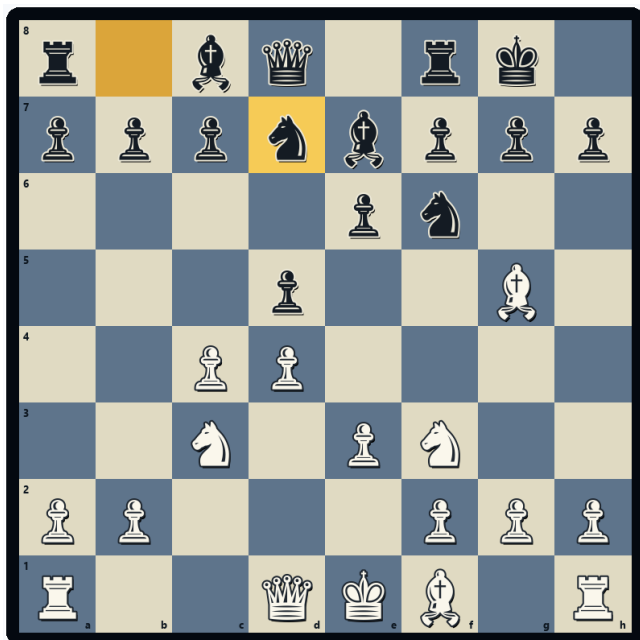
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Read the change first; make your plan second.

02. Loose Pieces Tell The Truth



DEFENSE, PROPHYLAXIS, AND COUNTERPLAY

READ THE POSITION

Identify what is loose, then ask which forcing move can exploit it.

PRIMARY PLAN

UNDEFENDED: Mark every piece defended zero times.; OVERLOADED: Find defenders tied to two duties.; ALIGNED: Trace kings, queens, and rooks on lines.; FORCING: Test checks, captures, and direct threats.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'I cannot see a tactic' with 'First inventory tactical targets.'; Replace 'It is defended' with 'Ask whether the defender can move.'; Replace 'Only checks matter' with 'Use captures and double attacks too.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Nf3 Be7 5. Bg5 O-O 6. e3 Nbd7

MEMORY RULE

Before hunting a tactic, find the pieces asking to be attacked.

02. Decision Framework

Loose Pieces Tell The Truth

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	INVENTORY: Find loose pieces for both sides.; COMPARE: Notice who has the weaker target.; GENERATE: Create forcing candidate moves.; CALCULATE: Follow the most forcing reply.; CLEANUP: Check what remains loose afterward.
PIECE JOB	UNDEFENDED: A piece with no defender is a standing invitation.; OVERLOADED: One defender may be doing two incompatible jobs.; ALIGNED: Pieces on one line invite pins, skewers, and discoveries.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	TARGETS: Combinations need something to attack.; DEFENDERS: Count their duties, not merely their number.; LINES: Geometry creates tactical possibilities.; BOTH SIDES: Your loose piece may refute your idea.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

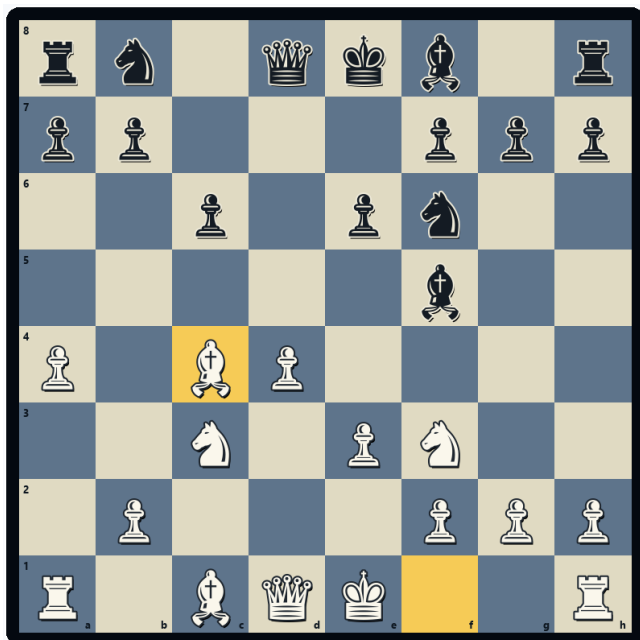
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NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Before hunting a tactic, find the pieces asking to be attacked.

03. Compare The Two Kings



DEFENSE, PROPHYLAXIS, AND COUNTERPLAY

READ THE POSITION

Compare access, defenders, and attacking pieces before opening lines.

PRIMARY PLAN

ACCESS: Count useful checking routes.; DEFENDERS: Count effective nearby defenders.; FORCES: Count attackers that can join quickly.; COST: Name what opening the position concedes.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'Their king looks open' with 'Ask whether your pieces can reach it.'; Replace 'My king is castled' with 'Check lines and missing defenders.'; Replace 'I should sacrifice' with 'Count arriving forces before material.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 dxc4 5. a4 Bf5 6. e3 e6 7. Bxc4

MEMORY RULE

Do not attack a picture; attack a king your pieces can reach.

03. Decision Framework

Compare The Two Kings

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	COMPARE: Inspect both kings, not only theirs.; ACCESS: Find checks that can actually arrive.; RECRUIT: Count pieces within two moves.; OPEN: Choose the safest useful line break.; RECHECK: Confirm your king survives the race.
PIECE JOB	ACCESS: Can checks reach the king without losing time?; DEFENDERS: Are nearby pieces able to protect critical squares?; FORCES: How many attackers can join before the position changes?
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	RELATIVE: King safety is always a comparison.; ACCESS: An exposed king may still be unreachable.; NUMBERS: Attack with more pieces than the defense.; COST: Opening lines works in both directions.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

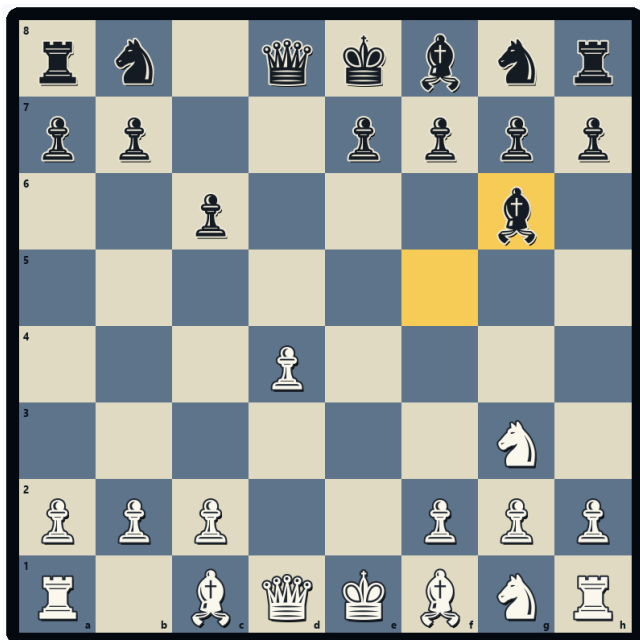
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NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Do not attack a picture; attack a king your pieces can reach.

04. Count Attackers And Defenders



DEFENSE, PROPHYLAXIS, AND COUNTERPLAY

READ THE POSITION

Include hidden defenders, pinned pieces, and the value of the final occupant.

PRIMARY PLAN

NUMBER: Count legal attackers and defenders.; QUALITY: Remove pinned or immobile defenders.; ORDER: Start exchanges with the least valuable piece.; RESULT: Picture the final piece on the square.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'It is defended twice' with 'Check whether both defenders can move.'; Replace 'I win the first capture' with 'Follow the entire exchange sequence.'; Replace 'The numbers are equal' with 'Compare the value and order too.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c6 2. d4 d5 3. Nc3 dxe4 4. Nxe4 Bf5 5. Ng3 Bg6

MEMORY RULE

When a square is crowded, replace intuition with an inventory.

04. Decision Framework

Count Attackers And Defenders

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	MARK: Identify the contested square.; COUNT: List legal attackers and defenders.; FILTER: Remove pieces that are pinned.; ORDER: Run captures from lowest value upward.; RESULT: Evaluate the final material and position.
PIECE JOB	NUMBER: Start with how many legal captures each side has.; QUALITY: Pinned or overloaded defenders may not truly defend.; ORDER: The cheapest attacker often determines the exchange sequence.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	LEGAL: A pinned piece may not be a defender.; ORDER: Capture sequence changes the arithmetic.; FINAL: Evaluate the last position, not the first trade.; POSITION: Material gain can still lose activity or king safety.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

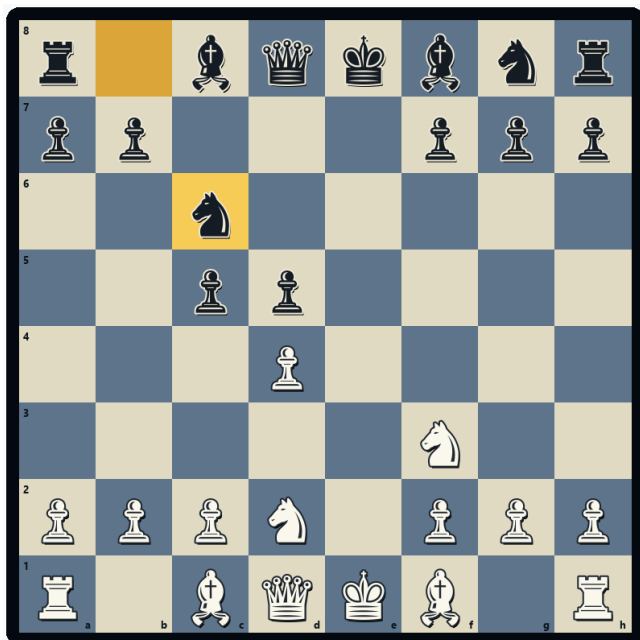
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NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: When a square is crowded, replace intuition with an inventory.

05. What Is The Opponent'S Idea?



DEFENSE, PROPHYLAXIS, AND COUNTERPLAY

READ THE POSITION

Find the opponent's strongest useful continuation, then decide whether it must be stopped.

PRIMARY PLAN

THREAT: What happens if I make a waiting move?;
IMPROVE: Which of their pieces wants a better square?;
URGENCY: Can the idea wait one move?; RESPONSE: Can my move answer it while improving?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'They attacked something' with 'Ask what happens if you ignore it.'; Replace 'I must stop their idea' with 'Judge whether it is actually urgent.'; Replace 'Defense means retreat' with 'Prefer a useful move with two purposes.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. Nd2 c5 4. exd5 exd5 5. Ng3 Nc6

MEMORY RULE

See their idea clearly, then respond by choice rather than fear.

05. Decision Framework

What Is The Opponent'S Idea?

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	WAIT: Imagine passing your turn.; PREDICT: Name their strongest next move.; VALUE: Judge what that move would gain.; DECIDE: Stop, delay, or ignore it.; MULTIPURPOSE: Choose a response that also improves.
PIECE JOB	THREAT: A real threat changes material, king safety, or structure.; IMPROVEMENT: A quiet move may activate their worst piece.; URGENCY: Some ideas can be met after you improve your own position.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	PREDICT: Name one serious opponent idea.; TEST: Use a waiting move to expose urgency.; SELECT: Not every idea deserves prevention.; IMPROVE: The best defense often serves your plan too.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

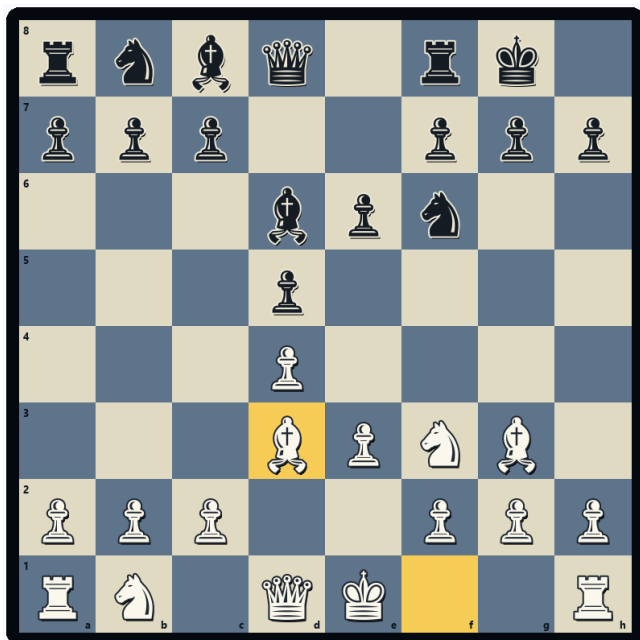
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NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: See their idea clearly, then respond by choice rather than fear.

06. When To Trade Pieces



REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. Nf3 Nf6 3. Bf4 e6 4. e3 Bd6 5. Bg3 O-O 6. Bd3

MEMORY RULE

Do not ask whether the pieces are equal; ask which position is better.

DEFENSE, PROPHYLAXIS, AND COUNTERPLAY

READ THE POSITION

Evaluate the position after the exchange, not the pieces disappearing from it.

PRIMARY PLAN

REMOVE: Which opponent piece is most useful?
STRUCTURE: What pawn structure remains?; ENDGAME: Who benefits from fewer pieces?; ACTIVITY: Which remaining piece gains freedom?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'Equal pieces can be traded' with 'Picture what improves after the trade.'; Replace 'I am ahead, so simplify' with 'Keep enough activity to convert.'; Replace 'Trade their attacker' with 'Check whether its replacement is stronger.'

06. Decision Framework

When To Trade Pieces

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	PICTURE: Remove both pieces mentally.; RECOUNT: Compare the remaining active pieces.; STRUCTURE: Inspect recaptures and new pawn targets.; ENDGAME: Judge the likely simplified position.; DECIDE: Trade only for a named benefit.
PIECE JOB	RELIEF: Exchange the opponent's piece that creates the most pressure.; STRUCTURE: Use trades that leave a durable target or passed pawn.; ENDGAME: Simplify when the remaining position is easier for you to play.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	FUTURE: An exchange is a positional transformation.; BEST PIECE: Trade what makes their position work.; RECAPTURE: The recapturing piece may gain activity.; CONVERSION: Simplification helps only if the ending helps.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

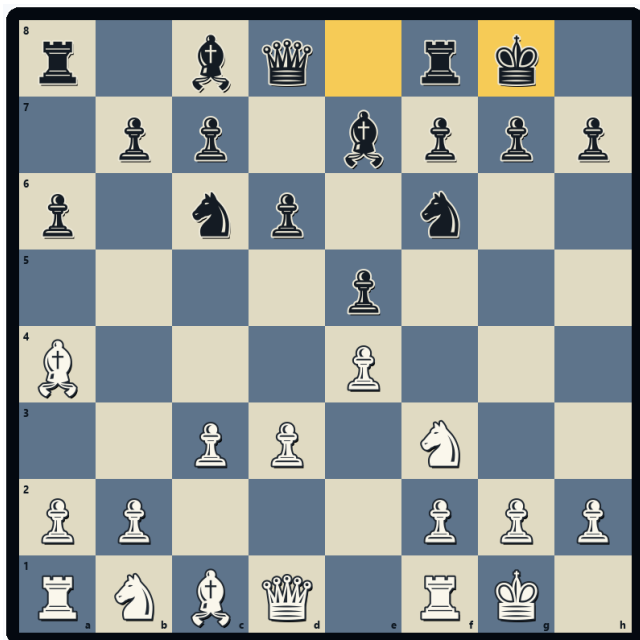
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NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Do not ask whether the pieces are equal; ask which position is better.

07. When Not To Trade Pieces



DEFENSE, PROPHYLAXIS, AND COUNTERPLAY

READ THE POSITION

Decline exchanges when your piece, space, or tension forces the opponent to remain uncomfortable.

PRIMARY PLAN

SPACE: Who needs room more urgently?; PRESSURE: Which piece maintains a useful burden?; TENSION: What options disappear after the exchange?; REPLACEMENT: What piece takes over the traded square?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'They offered a trade' with 'Ask whose problem the trade solves.'; Replace 'Avoiding trades is passive' with 'Preserve pieces that create pressure.'; Replace 'Capture to clarify' with 'Keep tension when uncertainty favors you.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. d3 d6 7. c3 O-O

MEMORY RULE

Keep the pieces and tensions that make the opponent's life difficult.

07. Decision Framework

When Not To Trade Pieces

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	PAUSE: Do not recapture automatically.; COMPARE: Identify who is cramped or pressured.; REMOVE: Visualize both pieces gone.; REPLACE: See which piece or pawn takes over.; CHOOSE: Maintain tension if it keeps options.
PIECE JOB	SPACE: The cramped side often wants pieces removed.; PRESSURE: An attacking piece may be worth more than its nominal value.; TENSION: Unresolved contact can restrict more than an immediate capture.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	RELIEF: Do not release a cramped opponent for free.; VALUE: Active pieces can exceed book value.; OPTIONS: Tension preserves choices and restricts replies.; PURPOSE: Every exchange should solve your problem.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

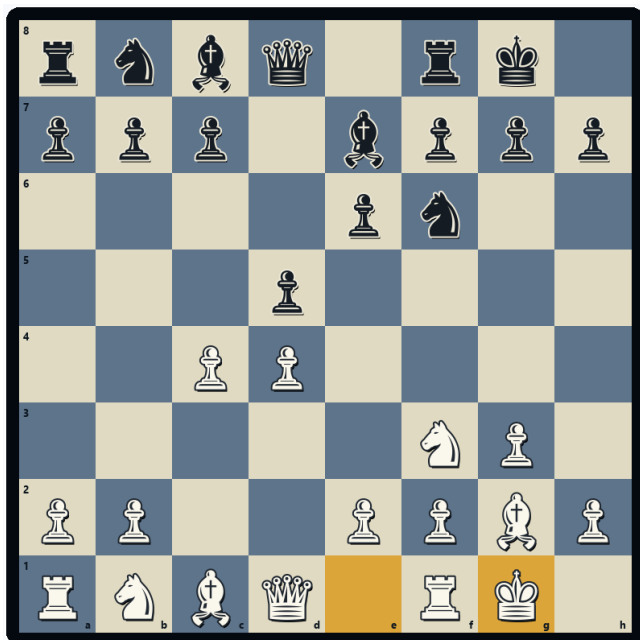
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NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Keep the pieces and tensions that make the opponent's life difficult.

08. Stop Counterplay Without Passivity



DEFENSE, PROPHYLAXIS, AND COUNTERPLAY

READ THE POSITION

Identify the freeing break, invasion square, or active piece that gives the opponent play.

PRIMARY PLAN

SOURCE: What creates their active play?; CONTROL: Can one move block or discourage it?; PROGRESS: Does the move improve your own position?; RELEASE: What happens if they achieve the break?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'Stop every threat' with 'Find the one source of activity.'; Replace 'Defend with retreat' with 'Use control, trades, or a useful blockade.'; Replace 'Keep attacking' with 'Spend one move removing their best resource.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 d5 4. g3 Be7 5. Bg2 O-O 6. O-O

MEMORY RULE

Good prevention does not stop your game; it clears the road for it.

08. Decision Framework

Stop Counterplay Without Passivity

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	PREDICT: Name their best active idea.; TRACE: Find the break or square it needs.; BLOCK: Choose the smallest effective restraint.; IMPROVE: Make the move serve your plan too.; CONTINUE: Return to conversion after control.
PIECE JOB	SOURCE: Counterplay usually depends on one break, file, or piece.; CONTROL: A single square can sometimes stop the entire idea.; PROGRESS: Your restraining move should preserve a path forward.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	ONE SOURCE: Counterplay is often structurally narrow.; MINIMUM: Use the least passive effective move.; DUAL PURPOSE: Restriction should also improve.; RETURN: Once controlled, continue your own plan.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

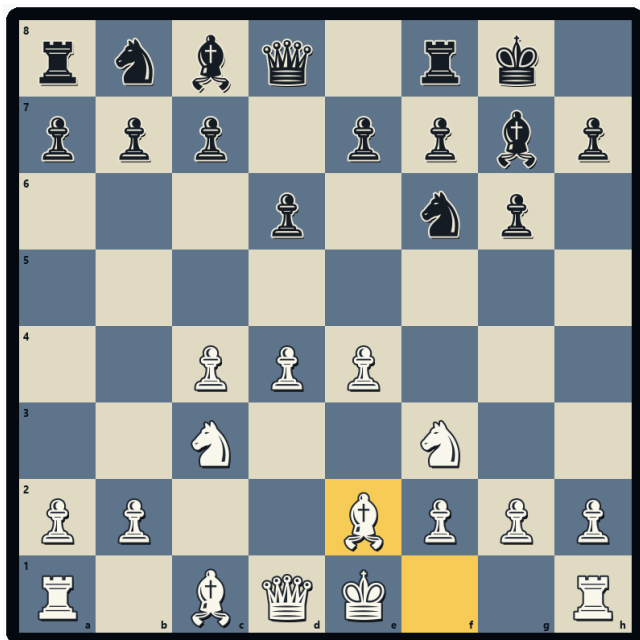
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NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Good prevention does not stop your game; it clears the road for it.

09. Keep Or Release The Tension?



DEFENSE, PROPHYLAXIS, AND COUNTERPLAY

READ THE POSITION

Compare capture, advance, and waiting before changing the structure.

PRIMARY PLAN

CAPTURE: What improves after the likely recapture?;
 ADVANCE: What squares become fixed or weak?; WAIT:
 Who benefits from maintaining tension?; REPLY: Can the
 opponent resolve it more favorably?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'Capture to simplify' with 'Inspect the opponent's
 recapturing piece.'; Replace 'Advance to gain space' with
 'Count the squares left behind.'; Replace 'I must decide
 now' with 'Wait when tension restricts them more.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. Nf3 O-O 6. Be2

MEMORY RULE

Do not release tension merely to make the position easier to understand.

09. Decision Framework

Keep Or Release The Tension?

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	COMPARE: Picture all three structural choices.; RECAPTURE: Place the opponent's piece after capture.; FIX: See what an advance makes permanent.; WAIT: Measure who has more useful options.; TIME: Resolve only for a concrete gain.
PIECE JOB	OPTIONS: Maintaining contact preserves more choices for you.; RECAPTURE: The opponent's recapturing piece may improve dramatically.; TIMING: A favorable resolution today may be unfavorable one move later.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	THREE CHOICES: Capture and advance are not the only moves.; RECAPTURE: Structure and activity change together.; OPTIONS: Tension can be a form of control.; TIMING: Resolve contact when the result favors you.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

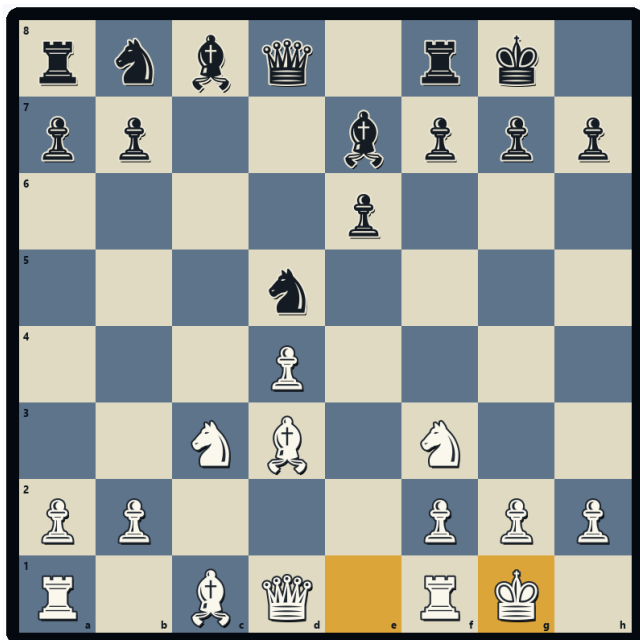
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NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Do not release tension merely to make the position easier to understand.

10. Exchange The Best Defender



DEFENSE, PROPHYLAXIS, AND COUNTERPLAY

READ THE POSITION

Identify the piece whose removal changes the opponent's entire defensive geometry.

PRIMARY PLAN

CONTROL: Which piece guards the key square?; JOBS: Which defender performs several duties?; REPLACE: What piece or pawn recaptures?; CHANGE: What becomes possible after removal?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'Trade the nearest defender' with 'Find the piece with the most duties.'; Replace 'Give up bishop for knight' with 'Name the squares gained afterward.'; Replace 'Exchange and then decide' with 'Calculate the replacement before trading.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c6 2. d4 d5 3. exd5 cxd5 4. c4 Nf6 5. Nc3 e6 6. Nf3 Be7 7. cxd5 Nxd5 8. Bd3 O-O 9. O-O

MEMORY RULE

Remove the piece that holds the position together, then act before it is replaced.

10. Decision Framework

Exchange The Best Defender

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	TARGET: Name the square or king you want to reach.; TRACE: Find every meaningful defender.; RANK: Identify the defender with multiple jobs.; REMOVE: Choose a favorable exchange method.; ENTER: Use the newly available route immediately.
PIECE JOB	CONTROL: One piece may guard the critical entry square.; CONNECTION: A defender can link otherwise scattered pieces.; REPLACEMENT: The value of exchange depends on what replaces it.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	FUNCTION: Judge defenders by the jobs they perform.; OVERLOAD: Multiple duties reveal the key piece.; REPLACEMENT: Recapture may repair the defense.; TIMING: Exploit the removal before regrouping.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

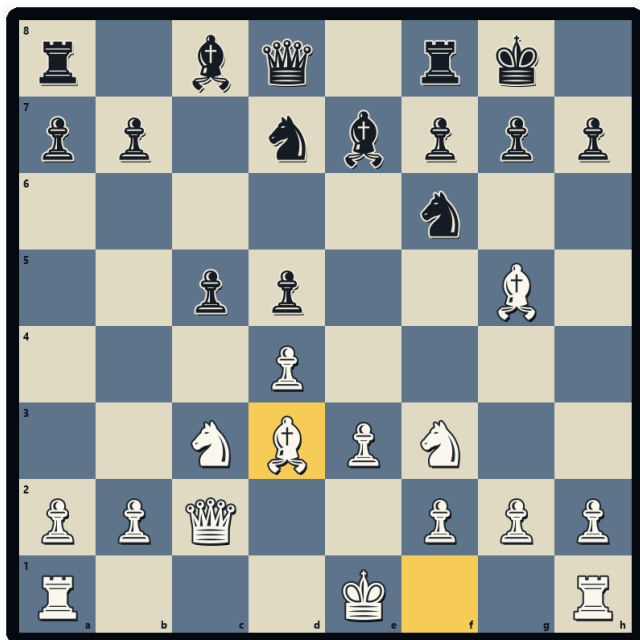
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NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Remove the piece that holds the position together, then act before it is replaced.

11. Forcing Moves With Purpose



DEFENSE, PROPHYLAXIS, AND COUNTERPLAY

READ THE POSITION

Generate forcing moves, then reject the ones that improve the opponent's position.

PRIMARY PLAN

FORCE: How many sensible replies remain?; RESULT: Where does the king or recapturing piece land?; PURPOSE: What does the move actually gain?; EXIT: Can you continue if the attack ends?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'Always check first' with 'Test whether the check improves their king.'; Replace 'Capture because it is forcing' with 'Evaluate the recapture and resulting activity.'; Replace 'Keep the initiative' with 'Know where the forcing sequence ends.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 d5 4. Nc3 Be7 5. Bg5 O-O 6. e3 Nbd7 7. Qc2 c5 8. cxd5 exd5 9. Bd3

MEMORY RULE

Use forcing moves to simplify the tree, then let evaluation choose the move.

11. Decision Framework

Forcing Moves With Purpose

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	LIST: Notice checks, captures, and direct threats.; FILTER: Remove moves with an obvious good reply.; FOLLOW: Calculate the opponent's most resistant answer.; STOP: Reach a stable position.; EVALUATE: Judge the result without excitement.
PIECE JOB	REPLIES: A forcing move reduces the opponent's reasonable choices.; RESULT: The final position still decides whether the move is good.; PURPOSE: Every check or capture should serve a tactical or positional aim.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	ATTENTION: Forcing moves deserve inspection, not obedience.; KING: A check may improve the king's location.; RECAPTURE: A capture can activate the opponent.; END: Know the position after the forcing moves stop.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

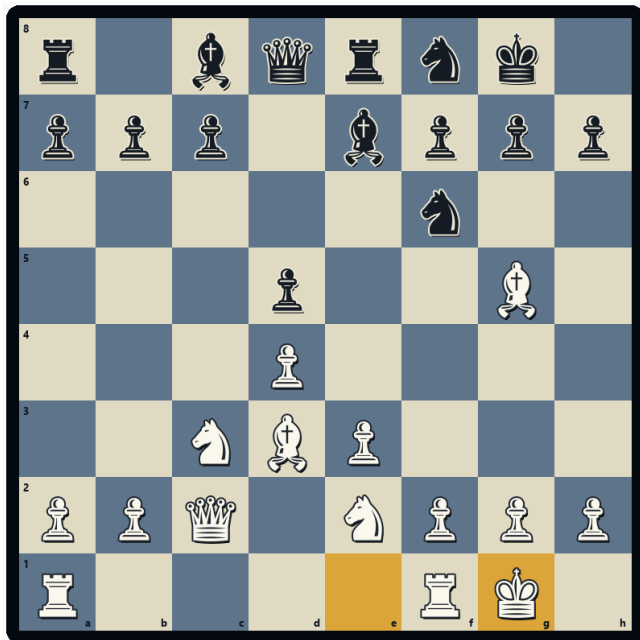
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5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Use forcing moves to simplify the tree, then let evaluation choose the move.

12. Calculate Until The Position Is Quiet



DEFENSE, PROPHYLAXIS, AND COUNTERPLAY

READ THE POSITION

Continue until checks, captures, and immediate threats no longer control the next move.

PRIMARY PLAN

FORCING: Does either side still have a forcing reply?; SAFETY: Are kings and major pieces stable?; EVALUATE: Who is better in the quiet position?; COMPARE: Apply the same stopping point to other lines.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'I saw three moves' with 'Continue if the position is still forcing.'; Replace 'I won material' with 'Check whether king safety or recapture changes it.'; Replace 'The line feels good' with 'Name the final stable evaluation.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Bg5 Be7 6. e3 O-O 7. Bd3 Nbd7 8. Qc2 Re8 9. Nge2 Nf8 10. O-O

MEMORY RULE

Do not stop because the line is long; stop because the position is stable.

12. Decision Framework

Calculate Until The Position Is Quiet

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	ENTER: Begin with the critical candidate.; FORCE: Follow the most demanding reply.; CLEAN: Resolve checks and captures.; STABILIZE: Reach a position with normal choices.; JUDGE: Evaluate material, safety, and activity.
PIECE JOB	FORCING: Unanswered forcing moves mean the line is unfinished.; STABILITY: Material, king safety, and loose pieces must be understandable.; EVALUATION: Only a quiet position can be compared reliably.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	DEPTH: Count stability, not a fixed number of moves.; UNFINISHED: Forcing replies mean calculation must continue.; QUIET: Stable positions can be evaluated honestly.; CONSISTENT: Compare candidates at equivalent endpoints.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

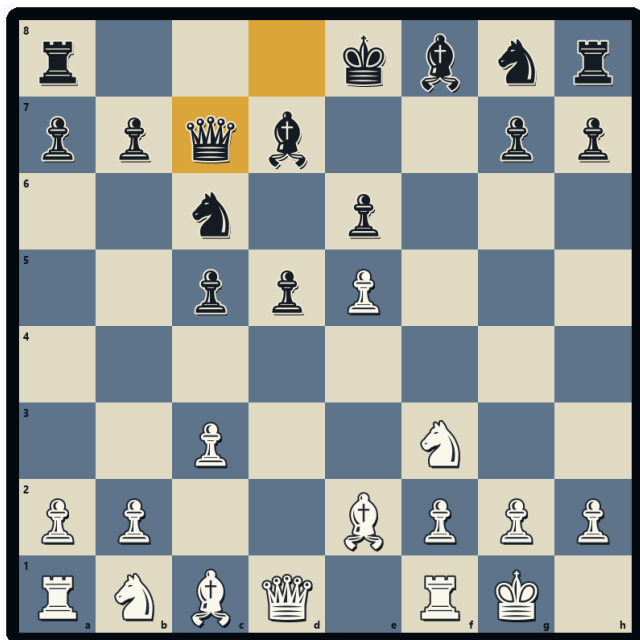
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Do not stop because the line is long; stop because the position is stable.

13. Stop Calculating Ghost Threats



DEFENSE, PROPHYLAXIS, AND COUNTERPLAY

READ THE POSITION

Check access, consequence, and timing before investing calculation time.

PRIMARY PLAN

ACCESS: Is the route legal and unobstructed?
 CONSEQUENCE: What exactly is won or threatened?
 TIMING: How many moves does the idea require?
 RESPONSE: Is there a simple answer if it happens?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'That move looks dangerous' with 'State the exact consequence.'; Replace 'I should prevent it now' with 'Check whether they can execute it in time.'; Replace 'Calculate every attacking move' with 'Reject illegal or harmless ideas immediately.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. e5 c5 4. c3 Nc6 5. Nf3 Bd7 6. Be2 f6 7. O-O fxex5 8. dxe5 Qc7

MEMORY RULE

Fear becomes manageable when you force it to become specific.

13. Decision Framework

Stop Calculating Ghost Threats

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	NAME: Say the feared move precisely.; VERIFY: Check path, legality, and protection.; DAMAGE: Describe the concrete result.; ANSWER: Find the simplest adequate response.; MOVE ON: Spend time elsewhere if it is harmless.
PIECE JOB	ACCESS: Can the threatening piece reach the square legally?; CONSEQUENCE: What concrete damage occurs if the move is played?; TIMING: Does the opponent have time, or can you create something stronger?
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	EXACT: A vague threat is not yet a threat.; LEGAL: Geometry and occupied squares matter.; DAMAGE: Name what the move accomplishes.; TIME: Reject harmless ideas before calculating them.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

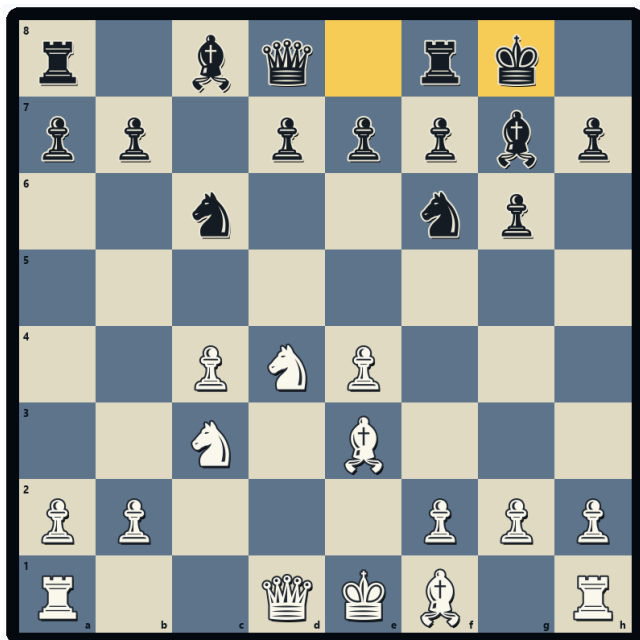
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Fear becomes manageable when you force it to become specific.

14. Calculate Defensively



DEFENSE, PROPHYLAXIS, AND COUNTERPLAY

READ THE POSITION

Identify what makes the threat work, then block, trade, move, or counterattack that element.

PRIMARY PLAN

MECHANISM: What exactly makes the threat work?;
 OPTIONS: Can you move, block, trade, or counter?;
 RESISTANCE: Choose their strongest continuation.; END: Is the resulting position actually safe?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'Save the attacked piece' with 'Break the mechanism behind the threat.'; Replace 'Defend the target again' with 'Consider trading the attacker instead.'; Replace 'Any move that survives' with 'Evaluate the position after the danger ends.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 g6 5. c4 Bg7 6. Be3 Nf6 7. Nc3 O-O

MEMORY RULE

Good defense removes the threat's engine, not only its visible target.

14. Decision Framework

Calculate Defensively

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	DEFINE: State the threat precisely.; DISSECT: Find its necessary line or defender.; GENERATE: Use all four defensive methods.; TEST: Give the opponent maximum resistance.; STABILIZE: Choose the safest playable result.
PIECE JOB	MECHANISM: A threat depends on a line, defender, target, or move order.; OPTIONS: Defense includes moving, blocking, trading, and counterattacking.; RESIDUE: After surviving, avoid a position with a different fatal weakness.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	MECHANISM: Attack the reason the threat works.; FOUR METHODS: Move, block, trade, or counterattack.; BEST REPLY: Do not defend against a cooperative opponent.; AFTERWARD: Survival must lead to a playable position.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

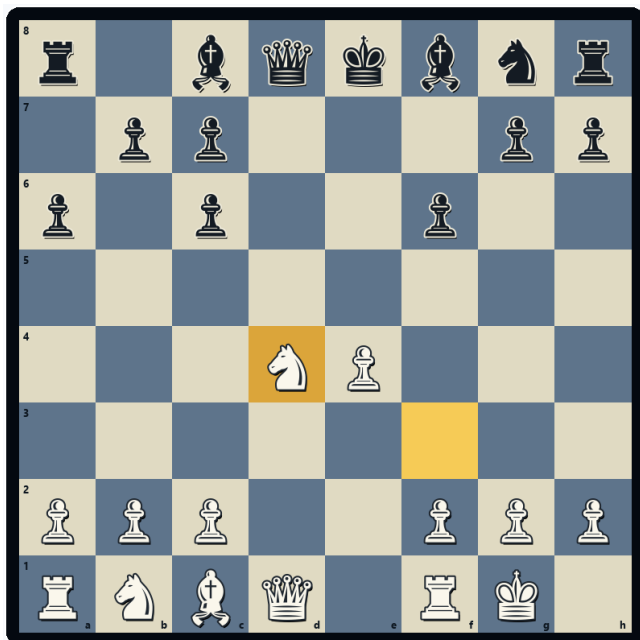
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Good defense removes the threat's engine, not only its visible target.

15. When To Calculate Deeply



DEFENSE, PROPHYLAXIS, AND COUNTERPLAY

READ THE POSITION

Calculate deeply when the move is forcing, irreversible, or changes the evaluation sharply.

PRIMARY PLAN

IRREVERSIBLE: Will the move permanently change structure or material?; UNSTABLE: Are forcing moves dominating?; CHOICES: Do candidates lead to different positions?; CLOCK: Can the decision justify the time cost?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'Calculate every candidate' with 'Screen moves before spending time.'; Replace 'Think longest when confused' with 'Look for critical features first.'; Replace 'Save all my time' with 'Invest it at irreversible crossroads.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Bxc6 dxc6 5. O-O f6 6. d4 exd4 7. Nxd4

MEMORY RULE

Use your clock on decisions that will shape the rest of the game.

15. Decision Framework

When To Calculate Deeply

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	SCREEN: Check for tactical or structural instability.; SHORTLIST: Keep two or three serious moves.; BUDGET: Choose a reasonable time limit.; CALCULATE: Follow the most critical response.; DECIDE: Stop when one line is clearly preferable.
PIECE JOB	IRREVERSIBLE: Pawn moves, sacrifices, and exchanges cannot be undone.; UNSTABLE: Exposed kings and loose pieces make evaluation volatile.; CHOICE: Critical positions offer several plausible but different paths.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	CRITICAL: Some moves deserve far more time than others.; IRREVERSIBLE: Permanent changes require care.; SCREEN: Do not calculate bad candidates deeply.; STOP: A clear preference is enough to decide.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

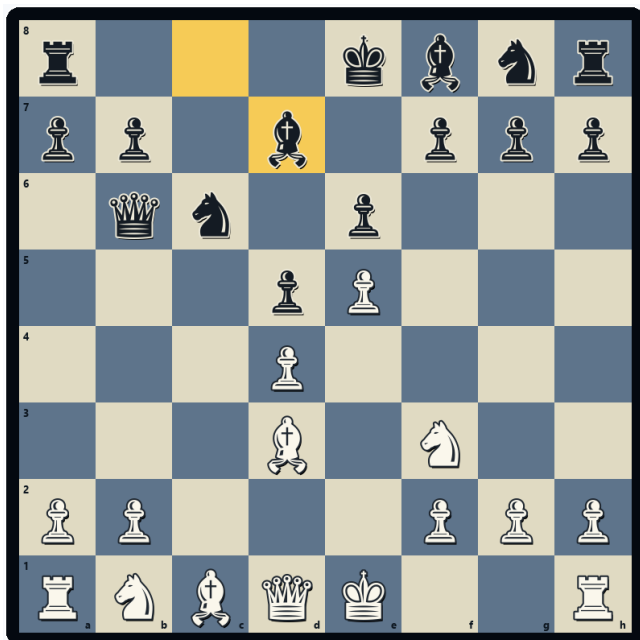
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Use your clock on decisions that will shape the rest of the game.

16. Use Your Clock Like A Budget



DEFENSE, PROPHYLAXIS, AND COUNTERPLAY

READ THE POSITION

Use fast routines for familiar positions and deliberate budgets for irreversible choices.

PRIMARY PLAN

BASELINE: What is your normal move budget?; **INVEST:** Is this position truly critical?; **RESERVE:** How much time must remain later?; **COMMIT:** When the budget ends, choose safely.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'More time finds truth' with 'Stop when one move is clearly adequate.'; Replace 'Think deeply in every position' with 'Use routines for ordinary decisions.'; Replace 'I will play fast later' with 'Protect a reserve before trouble begins.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. e5 c5 4. c3 Nc6 5. Nf3 Qb6 6. Bd3 cxd4 7. cxd4 Bd7

MEMORY RULE

Do not try to spend the same care on decisions of different importance.

16. Decision Framework

Use Your Clock Like A Budget

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	GLANCE: Check clock and game phase.; CLASSIFY: Ordinary or critical position?; BUDGET: Set a mental stopping point.; DECIDE: Use the best evidence available.; RESET: Begin the next move fresh.
PIECE JOB	BASELINE: Ordinary moves need a modest default time.; INVESTMENT: Critical positions deserve a deliberate larger spend.; RESERVE: Keep enough time to make safe decisions near the end.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	RESOURCE: Time is part of the position.; UNEQUAL: Critical moves deserve unequal spending.; RESERVE: Late safety requires saved time.; ENOUGH: A sound move on time beats perfection too late.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

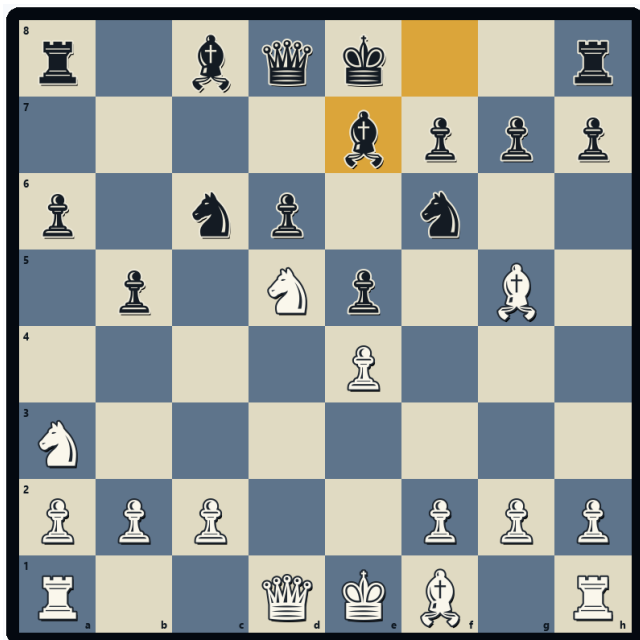
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Do not try to spend the same care on decisions of different importance.

17. Convert An Extra Pawn



DEFENSE, PROPHYLAXIS, AND COUNTERPLAY

READ THE POSITION

Activate the king and pieces, restrict counterplay, then use the majority to create a passed pawn.

PRIMARY PLAN

KING: Can your king reach the stronger side?; EXCHANGE: Which enemy piece creates counterplay?; MAJORITY: Where can you create a passed pawn?; COUNTERPLAY: What active resource must be stopped?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'Push the extra pawn' with 'Improve the king before committing pawns.'; Replace 'Trade everything' with 'Exchange activity, not useful helpers.'; Replace 'Protect every pawn' with 'Permit harmless losses for a winning passer.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 e5 6. Ndb5 d6 7. Bg5 a6 8. Na3 b5 9. Nd5 Be7

MEMORY RULE

An extra pawn becomes a win when the whole position helps it matter.

17. Decision Framework

Convert An Extra Pawn

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	ACTIVATE: Improve the king first.; RESTRICT: Remove the opponent's active resource.; EXCHANGE: Trade the piece that creates resistance.; CREATE: Use the majority to make a passer.; ESCORT: Advance with coordinated support.
PIECE JOB	KING: The king must help attack and escort pawns.; EXCHANGES: Trade active enemy pieces, not every piece automatically.; MAJORITY: Use the extra pawn to create a protected or distant passer.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	ACTIVITY: Material needs active help.; SELECTIVE: Not every exchange improves conversion.; PASSER: The extra pawn must gain a useful role.; CONTROL: Stop counterplay before racing.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

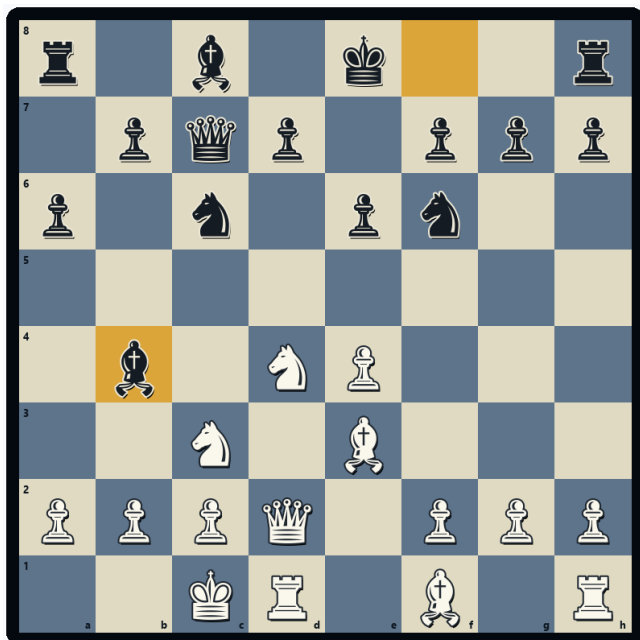
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: An extra pawn becomes a win when the whole position helps it matter.

18. Defend A Worse Position



DEFENSE, PROPHYLAXIS, AND COUNTERPLAY

READ THE POSITION

Reduce the opponent's easiest plan while preserving one source of counterplay.

PRIMARY PLAN

PLAN: What is their easiest winning plan?; TRADE: Which exchange disrupts it most?; COUNTERPLAY: What active resource can you preserve?; FORTRESS: Can you build a stable defensive setup?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'I should wait' with 'Force the opponent to solve a new problem.'; Replace 'Trade anything' with 'Trade the piece that enables their plan.'; Replace 'Create random threats' with 'Preserve credible, sustainable counterplay.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 e6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nc6 5. Nc3 Qc7 6. Be3 a6 7. Qd2 Nf6 8. O-O-O Bb4

MEMORY RULE

Defend the position by making the opponent prove every part of the win.

18. Decision Framework

Defend A Worse Position

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	ACCEPT: Evaluate the position without panic.; PREDICT: Name their simplest plan.; DISRUPT: Trade, blockade, or change structure.; ACTIVATE: Create one serious source of play.; RESIST: Make every step require accuracy.
PIECE JOB	RESISTANCE: Identify the plan they would choose with unlimited time.; TRADE: Exchange the piece that makes that plan simple.; COUNTERPLAY: Keep one credible threat or pawn break alive.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	NOT LOST: A disadvantage is an evaluation, not a result.; DIFFICULTY: Your job is to complicate conversion.; TARGETED TRADE: Remove the key winning piece.; ACTIVE: Keep one resource the opponent must respect.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

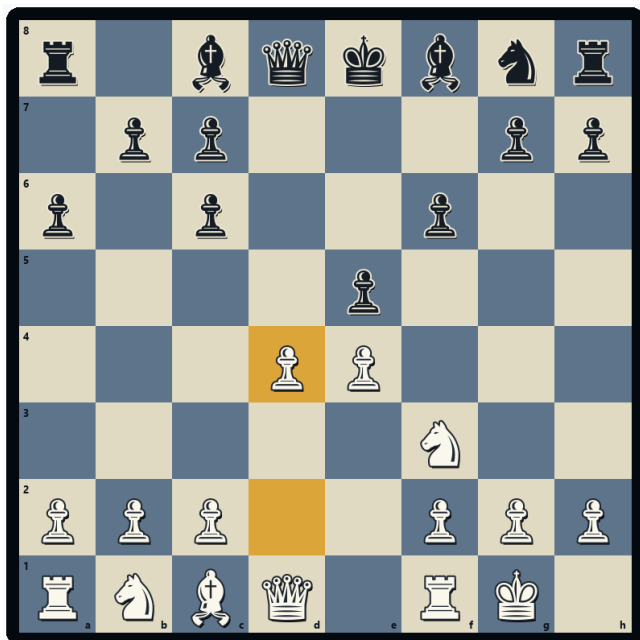
ACTIVE RECALL

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2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
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4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Defend the position by making the opponent prove every part of the win.

19. When You Have No Idea What To Do



DEFENSE, PROPHYLAXIS, AND COUNTERPLAY

READ THE POSITION

Remove immediate danger, improve the worst piece, or preserve useful options.

PRIMARY PLAN

SAFETY: Is anything loose or tactically vulnerable?; IMPROVE: Which piece has the least useful job?; FLEXIBLE: Which move preserves options?; OPPONENT: What idea should not be allowed?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'I need a plan' with 'Solve one concrete problem first.'; Replace 'Make a pawn move' with 'Prefer reversible piece improvement.'; Replace 'Copy a known idea' with 'Use what this position actually needs.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Bxc6 dxc6 5. O-O f6 6. d4

MEMORY RULE

When you have no plan, make the position easier for your future self.

19. Decision Framework

When You Have No Idea What To Do

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	BREATHE: Stop demanding a perfect move.; SAFETY: Remove tactical defects.; IMPROVE: Help the worst piece.; PRESERVE: Avoid unnecessary pawn commitments.; PLAY: Choose a sound move and continue.
PIECE JOB	SAFETY: A safe position gives future plans time to appear.; IMPROVEMENT: One better piece can reveal the next step.; FLEXIBILITY: A noncommittal move can keep several plans available.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	SMALL: A useful move need not solve everything.; SAFE: Stability creates future opportunities.; REVERSIBLE: Piece moves preserve more options than pawn moves.; REAL: Respond to the position, not your memory.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

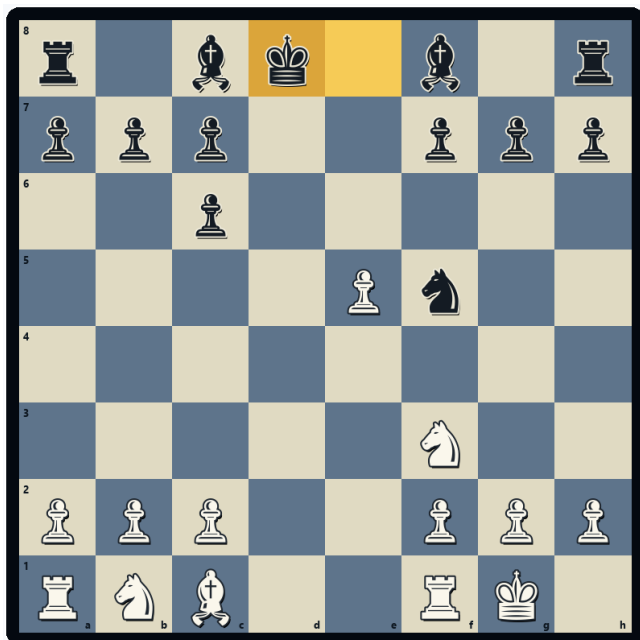
ACTIVE RECALL

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2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: When you have no plan, make the position easier for your future self.

20. Recover From A Bad Opening



DEFENSE, PROPHYLAXIS, AND COUNTERPLAY

READ THE POSITION

Finish development, protect the king, and challenge the opponent's most useful piece or space advantage.

PRIMARY PLAN

SAFETY: What immediate danger must be removed?;

DEVELOP: Which undeveloped piece can join?;

TRADE: Which enemy piece dominates the position?; BREAK: What pawn move could eventually free you?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'I must regain equality' with 'Aim for a stable playable position.'; Replace 'Attack to create chances' with 'Complete development before counterplay.'; Replace 'Avoid all exchanges' with 'Trade the piece that sustains their pressure.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 Nf6 4. O-O Nxe4 5. d4 Nd6 6. Bxc6 dxc6 7. dxe5 Nf5 8. Qxd8+ Kxd8

MEMORY RULE

A bad opening becomes survivable when you stop trying to erase it in one move.

20. Decision Framework

Recover From A Bad Opening

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	ACCEPT: Stop fighting the evaluation emotionally.; SECURE: Protect king and loose pieces.; DEVELOP: Bring every piece into the game.; REDUCE: Exchange the strongest enemy piece.; FREE: Prepare the structural break that creates room.
PIECE JOB	SAFETY: Stop immediate tactics and secure the king.; DEVELOPMENT: Bring unused pieces into defensive and active roles.; TRADE: Exchange the piece that makes the opponent's advantage easy.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	STABLE: Playable is the first recovery target.; ONE ERROR: Do not turn an opening mistake into several.; DEVELOP: Unused pieces cannot solve problems.; FREEING BREAK: Know the move that can restore space.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: A bad opening becomes survivable when you stop trying to erase it in one move.

Course Completion Test

Choose ten chapters at random. Rebuild each reference position, name both sides' plans, identify the critical break, and state the trade filter without reopening the chapter.

Score one point for the structure, one for your plan, one for counterplay, one for the break, and one for the memory rule. Forty out of fifty means the knowledge is usable; below forty means retrieval practice should continue.

FINAL PRINCIPLE

A course is complete when its ideas appear in your decisions, not when its pages have been read.